Mehfil-e-Zan

Gather. Grow. Glow.

HR AND EMPLOYEE MANAGEMENT POLICY

Fair, consistent and respectful people practices, from hiring to farewell

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Applies to	All employees, trainees, interns, instructors and contractors, and everyone who recruits, supervises or keeps records of staff

Student project note: *This document is a student project deliverable. Probation periods, leave days, notice periods, working hours and other figures are business assumptions. Labour, social security, tax and data protection rules must be checked for Pakistan and Sindh, and reviewed by a qualified adviser, before a real business adopts this policy.*

1. Purpose and Scope

1.1 Purpose

Mehfil-e-Zan is a women-only cafe and community space. Our people make it safe and warm. This policy sets out how we hire, support, evaluate and part with our team in a way that is fair, consistent and easy to understand. It protects employees and the business.

1.2 Scope

This policy covers every stage of employment: recruitment, selection, onboarding, attendance, leave, performance, training, equal opportunity, respectful conduct, grievances, records, resignation and exit. Client-facing conduct is in MEZ-SOP-008. Day-to-day conduct and discipline are in MEZ-SOP-001.

1.3 Business assumptions

- Mehfil-e-Zan is open daily from 10:00 AM to 10:00 PM in Gulshan-e-Iqbal, Karachi, with 40 seats. All staff are women.
- The team has 11 core roles, supported by part-time baristas, kitchen helpers, cleaners and workshop instructors as needed.
- Salaries and fees are in Pakistani rupees (PKR) and follow the pay scale approved by the CEO and Finance Director.
- Staff are paid on or before the 7th of each month by bank transfer, against a payslip.

1.4 Related documents

Document ID	Title	Link to this policy
MEZ-SOP-001	General Office SOP	Conduct, discipline, escalation
MEZ-SOP-002	Security Measures SOP	Safety, privacy, incidents
MEZ-SOP-007	Professional Communication Ethics SOP	Respectful communication, harassment
MEZ-SOP-008	Client Communication and Engagement Ethics SOP	Client conduct, conflicts of interest
MEZ-POL-001	IT Rules and Regulations Policy	Access to records, data protection
MEZ-SOP-009	Finance and Expense Management SOP	Salaries, claims, payroll controls
MEZ-FRM-032 to 037	HR forms (Annexes A to F)	Job description, scoring, leave, evaluation, grievance, exit

Note: *Document and form numbers are assumed and should be matched to the master Document Register.*

2. Roles and Responsibilities

Role	Responsibilities under this policy
Owner and CEO	Approve this policy, the pay scale and the staffing plan. Approve hiring of managers, final warnings, dismissals and serious grievance outcomes.
HR / Sales / Marketing Manager	Owns this policy. Runs recruitment and onboarding, handles leave and attendance rules, runs evaluations, receives grievances and keeps training records.
Finance Director	Confirms budget before hiring. Runs payroll, deductions and final settlements.
Supervisor	Prepares rosters, records daily attendance, coaches the team and does first-line performance feedback.
Operations Officer	Plans shifts with the Supervisor and tells HR about staffing gaps.
IT Manager	Controls access to HR files and removes system access on exit.
Security & Safety Manager	Issues and collects staff ID cards, keys and access. Supports safe-workplace and incident checks.
Documentation & Compliance Coordinator	Keeps personnel files, retention schedule and policy acknowledgements. Checks that records are complete.
Sales and Marketing Executives	Follow this policy, complete training and help new joiners settle in.
All employees	Know and follow this policy, keep their own details up to date and raise concerns early.

3. Guiding Principles

Principle	What it means in practice
Fairness	The same rules and the same pay scale apply to everyone in the same role. Decisions are based on skills, behaviour and facts.
Respect and dignity	Everyone is treated kindly, whatever her language, class, background, religion, age, appearance or marital status.
Transparency	People know what is expected, how they are assessed and who to ask for help.
Confidentiality	Personal and pay information is shared only with those who need it.
Growth	We invest in training because women who learn and earn make the whole community stronger.
Safety	A woman can work here without fear of harassment, pressure or retaliation.

4. Workforce Planning and Recruitment

4.1 When we recruit

- A manager raises a **Staffing Request** explaining the need, the role and the expected cost.

- The Finance Director confirms the budget. The CEO approves any new permanent post.
- HR prepares or updates the job description (Annex A) before advertising.

4.2 Where we advertise

Vacancies are shared on our own Instagram, Facebook and WhatsApp channels, in women-focused job groups and through universities and community networks. Referrals from staff are welcome, but referred candidates go through the same process as everyone else.

4.3 Honest job advertisements

- The advert states the role, duties, location, shift pattern and that the workplace is women-only.
- It does not make promises about pay, growth or benefits that the business cannot keep.
- It does not ask for photos, marital status, family details or religion. Age or education limits are used only when the job genuinely needs them.

5. Job Descriptions

Every role has a written job description. It is the base for hiring, onboarding, evaluation and fair pay.

Section	What it contains
Role summary	Job title, department, reporting line, employment type and shift pattern.
Main duties	5 to 8 clear duties in plain language.
Skills and qualifications	What is essential and what is nice to have. Skills are listed before degrees.
Working conditions	Hours, weekly off, standing or desk work, handling of food or cash.
Performance measures	How success in this role is measured (see Section 10).
Review	Date prepared, approved by, and the next review date. Reviewed yearly.

6. Selection and Hiring

6.1 Steps

1. **Screening.** HR checks applications against the essential criteria in the job description.
2. **Interview.** At least two people interview, one from HR and one from the hiring department. Questions are the same for all candidates for that role.
3. **Practical test** where useful, such as a barista trial, a customer-service role-play or a short writing task. Candidates are paid a fair amount if the trial exceeds two hours.
4. **Scoring.** Each panel member scores independently using Annex B. Scores and notes are kept.
5. **Reference and document checks.** Two references and CNIC verification. Checks are done only with the candidate’s written permission.
6. **Decision and offer.** The HR / Sales / Marketing Manager recommends. The CEO approves. A written offer is sent with pay, start date, probation and notice terms.

6.2 Rules

- No one interviews or decides on a relative or close friend. The person declares the link and steps out (see MEZ-SOP-008, Section 14).
- Interview questions never ask about marriage plans, pregnancy, children or family income.
- Unsuccessful candidates are told politely within 14 days. Their records are deleted after 6 months, unless they agree to be kept for future roles.
- Staff must be at least 18 years old. Trainees and interns have a written learning plan and a named mentor.

7. Onboarding and Probation

7.1 First week

When	What happens	Responsible
Before day 1	Signed offer and contract, personnel file opened, ID card and uniform prepared.	HR, Security & Safety Manager
Day 1	Welcome, tour, introduction to the team, review of safety, privacy and prayer-area rules. Policy acknowledgement signed.	HR, Supervisor
Days 2 to 5	Role training with a buddy. Food hygiene, cash handling, CRM and WhatsApp rules as needed.	Supervisor, IT Manager
End of week 1	Check-in: Is the role clear? Does she feel safe and supported?	HR
Day 30 and day 60	Progress check against the job description.	Supervisor, HR

7.2 Probation

New employees have a **3-month probation period** (assumed). The employee receives written feedback at one month and two months. At the end, HR and the Supervisor recommend: confirm, extend once by up to 1 month, or end employment. The decision is given in writing before the probation ends.

8. Working Hours and Attendance

Item	Rule (assumed)
Shifts	Morning shift 9:00 AM to 5:30 PM. Evening shift 2:00 PM to 10:30 PM. Office roles work 9:30 AM to 5:30 PM. Each shift has a 30-minute meal break and short prayer breaks.
Working week	Six working days a week with one paid weekly off, planned fairly on a rotating roster. The roster is shared at least 7 days ahead.
Recording	Attendance is recorded daily by the Supervisor in the attendance register or system.
Lateness	More than 15 minutes late counts as late. Three late arrivals in a month lead to a friendly conversation. Repeated lateness is handled under Section 15.
Absence	Employees tell the Supervisor before the shift starts, or as early as possible, through the staff WhatsApp group or by phone.

Item	Rule (assumed)
Overtime	Only with prior approval from the Supervisor. It is paid or given as time off in lieu, as the law requires.
Safe travel	When a shift ends after 9:00 PM, the Supervisor checks that the employee has a safe way home.

9. Leave

Leave type	Entitlement (assumed)	How to apply
Annual leave	14 working days a year after probation	Annex C at least 7 days ahead
Casual leave	8 days a year	Tell the Supervisor, record on Annex C
Sick leave	8 days a year. A medical certificate is needed for 3 or more days.	Inform on day 1, Annex C on return
Maternity leave	As required by Sindh and federal law. The business assumes at least 90 days paid. Job and role are protected.	Tell HR as early as comfortable. Annex C
Public holidays	As notified by the government. Staff who work on a holiday get time off in lieu or extra pay.	Roster
Compassionate leave	Up to 5 days for the death or serious illness of a close family member	Tell HR as soon as possible
Unpaid leave	Case by case, approved by the HR / Sales / Marketing Manager	Annex C

- The Supervisor approves up to 3 days. HR approves longer leave. Replies are given within 2 working days.
- Leave is refused only for clear business reasons, and the reason is written down. Another date is offered.
- No one is penalised for taking leave she is entitled to.

10. Performance Evaluation

10.1 Cycle

Step	When	Who
Goal setting	Within the first month and every January	Employee and Supervisor
Regular check-ins	Monthly, 15 minutes	Employee and Supervisor
Formal evaluation	At the end of probation, then every 6 months (June and December)	Supervisor and HR
Review meeting	Within 2 weeks of the evaluation	Employee, Supervisor, HR if needed

10.2 What is assessed (Annex D)

Area	Weight	Examples
Quality and results of work	30%	Accuracy, hygiene standards, targets met, tasks finished on time
Client care and teamwork	25%	Warm service, cooperation, helping others
Reliability and attendance	15%	Punctuality, following the roster
Honesty, privacy and safety	15%	Following privacy, cash and safety rules
Learning and initiative	15%	Training completed, ideas shared

Ratings use a 1 to 5 scale. The employee writes her own comments, signs, and may add a different view. Pay reviews and promotions use the evaluation together with budget and need. They are never based on personal preference.

11. Training and Development

Training	Who	When
Induction, safety and privacy	All new staff	First week
Food safety and hygiene	Kitchen, cafe and service staff	Before handling food, then yearly
Client communication and ethics (MEZ-SOP-008)	Anyone dealing with clients	First week, then yearly
First aid and fire safety	At least 2 staff per shift	Yearly
IT and data protection	All staff using systems	First month, then yearly
Professional skills	By role: sales, social media, bookkeeping, event management	Planned in the yearly budget

- Each employee has a simple development plan, agreed at the review meeting.
- Staff may attend our own community workshops free of charge, as seats allow.
- Training records are kept in the personnel file. Training given to local women instructors is recorded in the same way.

12. Equal Opportunity

- We recruit, pay, train and promote on merit. We do not discriminate on the basis of ethnicity, language, religion or sect, class, family background, disability, age, appearance or marital status.
- Pay for the same role and level is the same. Pay bands are reviewed yearly for fairness.
- We make reasonable adjustments for employees with disabilities, health conditions, pregnancy or caring duties, for example changed seating, rest breaks or a changed roster.

- Prayer and fasting needs are respected. Prayer space and breaks are provided.
- Staff may report unfair treatment under Section 14. No one is punished for raising a concern in good faith.

13. Respectful Workplace

13.1 Standards

- Speak and act with courtesy. No shouting, humiliation, insults, rumours or gossip about colleagues.
- No bullying, harassment, threats, intimidation or unwanted comments or contact, in person, on WhatsApp or on social media.
- Respect privacy. Do not photograph colleagues or guests without consent (MEZ-SOP-002).
- Keep team WhatsApp groups work-related and polite (MEZ-SOP-007).

13.2 Harassment

Harassment at the workplace is a serious misconduct. The business follows the applicable law on protection against harassment of women at the workplace, including an Inquiry Committee. The CEO appoints a committee of three, including at least one woman who is not in the complainant's reporting line. Complaints are kept strictly confidential, and retaliation is a disciplinary offence.

14. Grievance Procedure

Step	What happens	Time (assumed)
1. Talk	The employee raises the issue with her Supervisor, or with HR if the issue involves the Supervisor.	As soon as possible
2. Written grievance	If not solved, she submits Annex E to HR. HR logs it in the Grievance Register and confirms receipt.	Receipt within 2 working days
3. Review	HR listens to all sides, checks facts and may involve a neutral manager. Notes are kept confidentially.	Within 10 working days
4. Decision	HR gives a written decision with reasons and actions.	Within 15 working days of Step 2
5. Appeal	If she is not satisfied, she appeals to the CEO. The CEO's decision is final inside the business.	Appeal within 5 days. Decision within 10 days

- She may bring a trusted colleague to any meeting.
- Grievances involving the CEO or Owner go to a person chosen by the Owner or an external adviser.
- The Grievance Register is reviewed monthly for patterns, and HR reports numbers (without names) to the CEO.

15. Fair Discipline

Discipline is used to help people improve first. It must be fair, proportionate and recorded.

Stage	When used	Result
Informal talk	Minor issues such as lateness	Notes kept by the Supervisor
Verbal warning	Repeated minor issues	Recorded in the personnel file
Written warning	Continued issues or a moderate breach	Signed copy given to the employee
Final warning or suspension	Serious breach	CEO approval needed
Termination	Gross misconduct such as theft, fraud, harassment, breach of guest privacy, violence	CEO and Owner approval. Written notice with reasons

The employee is told the concern, may explain her side and may bring a colleague. For gross misconduct she may be suspended on pay while facts are checked. She can appeal to the CEO within 5 days.

16. Confidential Employee Records

16.1 What is kept

Each employee has one personnel file containing her application, contract, CNIC copy, job description, attendance and leave records, evaluations, training records, warnings, grievances and exit documents. Medical details and grievance files are kept in a separate, more restricted folder.

16.2 Rules

Rule	Detail
Access	Only the HR / Sales / Marketing Manager, the CEO, the Owner, the Documentation & Compliance Coordinator and (for pay only) the Finance Director. Each access is logged.
Storage	Paper files in a locked cabinet. Digital files in a restricted drive with a password and two-step verification (MEZ-POL-001).
Sharing	Employee data is shared outside only when the law requires, or with her written consent, for example a reference or bank letter.
Accuracy	Employees can see their own file and ask for corrections.
Retention	Employee files are kept for 5 years after exit (assumed, check the law). Unsuccessful applications for 6 months. Then safely destroyed and logged.
Breach	Any loss or wrongful sharing is reported at once to the IT Manager and HR. It is investigated and may lead to discipline.

17. Resignation and Exit

17.1 Resignation

- The employee gives written notice to HR. The notice period is **30 days** for permanent staff after probation and **7 days** during probation (assumed).
- HR acknowledges in writing within 2 working days and agrees the last working day.
- The employer gives equal notice or pay in lieu when ending employment without misconduct.

17.2 Exit steps (Annex F)

1. Handover of tasks, passwords, files, keys, uniform, ID card and equipment, signed by the Supervisor.
2. IT Manager removes access to email, WhatsApp groups, CRM, social media and drive on the last day.
3. Security & Safety Manager collects access items and updates the access list.
4. Finance Director prepares the final settlement: salary, unused leave if payable, and any lawful deductions. It is paid within 14 days of the last day.
5. HR holds an exit conversation, kindly and privately. Feedback is used to improve and is summarised without names.
6. HR issues an experience letter on request. It states only facts: role and dates.
7. Staff who leave on good terms are welcomed back as guests and invited to our alumni circle.

18. Compliance, Review and Approval

18.1 Training and acknowledgement

- Every employee reads this policy in her first week and signs an acknowledgement. A refresher is held every year.

18.2 Compliance checks

Check	Frequency	Responsible
Personnel files complete and secure	Quarterly	Documentation & Compliance Coordinator
Attendance and leave records match payroll	Monthly	Finance Director and Supervisor
Evaluations completed on time	Twice a year	HR / Sales / Marketing Manager
Grievance Register reviewed and actions closed	Monthly	HR / Sales / Marketing Manager
Training matrix up to date	Quarterly	HR / Sales / Marketing Manager
System access matches current staff list	Quarterly	IT Manager
Full review of this policy	Yearly	CEO and Owner

18.3 Approval

Role	Name	Signature	Date
Prepared by: HR / Sales / Marketing Manager			
Reviewed by: Finance Director			
Approved by: CEO			
Approved by: Owner			

Annex A. Job Description Template (MEZ-FRM-032)

Field	Details
Job title	
Department and reporting line	
Employment type and shift pattern	
Role summary	
Main duties (5 to 8)	
Essential skills and qualifications	
Nice-to-have skills	
Working conditions	
Performance measures	
Prepared by and date	
Approved by and next review date	

Annex B. Interview Scoring Sheet (MEZ-FRM-033)

Candidate: _____ Position: _____ Panel member: _____ Date: _____

Criteria (from job description)	Score 1 to 5	Notes

Annex C. Leave Application Form (MEZ-FRM-034)

Field	Details
Employee name and role	
Leave type	
From and to dates (number of days)	
Reason (optional for annual leave)	
Cover arrangements	
Employee signature and date	
Supervisor decision and date	
HR decision (if over 3 days) and date	
Leave balance after approval	

Annex D. Performance Evaluation Form (MEZ-FRM-035)

Employee: _____ Role: _____ Period: _____ Evaluator: _____

Area	Rating 1 to 5	Evidence and comments

Annex E. Grievance Form (MEZ-FRM-036)

Field	Details
Employee name and role (can be kept confidential on request)	
Date	
What happened (dates, places, people involved)	
Steps already taken to solve it	
What outcome would you like?	
Witnesses or documents	
Employee signature	
Received by HR and date	
Register number	

Annex F. Exit Checklist (MEZ-FRM-037)

Task	Done (date and initials)
Resignation letter received and acknowledged	
Last working day agreed	
Handover of tasks and files signed by Supervisor	
Keys, ID card, uniform and equipment returned	
System and group access removed by IT Manager	
Final settlement prepared by Finance Director	
Exit conversation held and feedback noted	
Experience letter issued if requested	
Personnel file closed and retention date set	
File closed by	